

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur

A plea to protect *Naattu Kaalvai*

Residents seek desilting, removal of encroachments and prevention of sewage discharge into the canal

T. ARVIND

A Right to Information response dated June 24, 2026 from Water Resource Department has stated that a revised proposal estimated at ₹44.10 crore had been submitted to the State government for comprehensive restoration of the Naattu Kaalvai.

This should come as some relief to residents of Saraswathipuram, Rangapuram and adjoining localities in Tiruneermalai who have been waging a long battle to remove encroachments, desilt the Naattu Kaalvai and prevent the discharge of sewage and effluents into the canal.

The localities, which were formerly under the Tiruneermalai Town Panchayat and now fall under Ward 31 of Tambaram Corporation, depend on the canal for the drainage of surplus water from waterbodies including Tiruneermalai Periya Eri and Veeraraghavan Eri.

The latest RTI states that the proposed works would include the



construction of 3,200 metres of flood-retaining walls on both sides of the canal. According to the department, the project would prevent floodwater from breaching the canal and inundating adjoining residential colonies.

Flooding concerns

According to residents and activists,

surplus water from these tanks flows through the Naattu Kaalvai, passing through Saraswathipuram, Ranga Nagar, the Tiruneermalai temple town, Jain Housing and other residential areas before joining the Adyar river. However, encroachments, silt accumulation and sewage inflow have reduced the carrying capacity

Naattu Kaalvai at Tiruneermalai Main Road; and a narrow stretch of it near Saraswathipuram Extension Fourth Street. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

of the canal, resulting in frequent inundation during heavy rain.

"During intense spells of rain, the bridge across the Naattu Kaalvai on Tiruneermalai Main Road near Saraswathipuram becomes virtually inaccessible," said social activist Santhanam. He said periodic desilting and removal of encroachments could significantly improve the free flow of storm water.

Residents have been pursuing the issue through Right to Information (RTI) applications since 2016.

A response received from WRD in October 2024 acknowledged the presence of encroachments and other deficiencies along the canal. The department also stated that it had requested Tambaram Corporation to prevent garbage dumping and the illegal discharge of sewage into the waterway.

Canal narrowed

Saravanan said portions of the canal, originally about 60 ft wide, have narrowed to nearly 15 ft and, in some stretches, to around 10 ft because of encroachments.

"Some encroachments were removed after the 2015 floods. Ho-

wever, several stretches remain affected, restricting the flow of water and causing inundation even during moderate rainfall," he said.

Residents identified Saraswathipuram Extension, Ranga Nagar, Subburaya Nagar, Kasi Garden and parts of the Tiruneermalai temple town among the worst-affected areas.

Call for early action

Residents have urged WRD to secure approval for the ₹53.13-crore proposal and commence restoration works before the onset of the northeast monsoon. They also sought deepening and desilting of the canal, strengthening of retaining walls, action against sewage and industrial effluent discharge, and the removal of remaining encroachments. Residents have further proposed covering the canal with concrete slabs while providing inspection chambers at regular intervals for maintenance and desilting operations. They also sought the construction of a connecting bridge between Saraswathipuram Second Street and Saraswathipuram Extension Fourth Street to improve accessibility across the canal. Residents said the long-pending issues, which have remained unresolved for over a decade, require immediate intervention to mitigate flood risk and restore the canal's drainage function.

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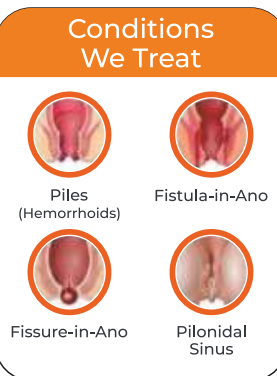
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Open a renewal counter in Nanganallur for seniors

V. RAMA RAO

At the Metropolitan Transport Corporation's Alandur bus depot, the counter for issuing bus tokens to senior citizens from July to December this year has been closed.

The seniors were directed to go to the counters at Vijaya Nagar terminus in Velachery or to Pallavaram, both of which are at a long distance.

At Hindu Colony in Nanganallur, there is a bus terminus, and much of the space remains unused. Facilitating counters for bus tokens will be helpful for the elderly residing in the Adambakkam, Pazhavanthangal, Alandur, Madipakkam, Moovarasampet, Ullagaram and Puzhuthivakkam



regions.

The Federation of Senior Citizen Associations of Tamil Nadu has sent a letter in this regard to C. Joseph Vijay, Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu.

V. Rama Rao is the president of the Federation of Senior Citizen Associations of Tamil Nadu

TAMILARASI K

Vinoth Children's Park in Thiru Vi Ka Nagar, Tambaram, has been neglected for a long time. The park lacks proper maintenance, cleanliness and lighting, making it unsafe and unpleasant for visitors especially children.

The play equipment is unusable, leaving very few facilities for children to enjoy.

Pets urinating and defecating within the premises is another concern.

The park has a large tree that provides much-needed shade and greenery, and any renovation or improvement work should be carried out without causing damage to it.

As this is one of the few recreational spaces available for children, immediate action is needed to repair the play



Poor maintenance of a park in Tambaram

equipment, improve sanitation, install adequate lighting and ensure proper regulation of park activities.

D. Sarath Kumar, MLA for the Tambaram Assembly con-

stituency, and the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation authorities are requested to take swift action to restore the park for the benefit of the community.

Durga Nagar Road in a sorry state

A. LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

The stretch of Durga Nagar Road from GST Road, opposite Chromepet Police Station, is in a poor condition.

Complaints lodged through the Voice of Tambaram app have not evoked any response.

I request the concerned authorities of the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to mend the stretch before any fatal accident occurs.

A. Lakshmi Narayanan is a resident of Tambaram Sanatorium



Pedestrian signal needed at Tambaram Sanatorium

S. SULOCHANA

A pedestrian signal is needed on GST Road in Tambaram Sanatorium. Both Tambaram City Police Commissionerate and State Highways Department should work towards getting a signal installed between the median walls.

Ever since the main entrance of the Government Hospital of Thoracic Medicine was shifted near the Government Chengalpattu District Hospital to facilitate construction of a new building, the Commissionerate made the traffic signals non-functional.

The pedestrian signal posts were also removed. At the same time, the Department put up median walls opposite the TB Hospi-



The State Highways Department has constructed median walls opposite the TB Hospital on GST Road in Tambaram Sanatorium.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tal.

A pedestrian crossing with traffic signals has been created outside the District Hospital. Earlier, bus commuters could cross outside the TB Hospital and board

buses. Now, the commuters and pedestrians can cross along Chromepet GH (dental wing) and board the buses at its haltover towards Tambaram (West).

Similarly, pedestrians going to

Appa Rao Colony and Kamatchi Colony, but have to cover extra distance.

To reach Vedantham Colony, Kamarajar Nagar and Jaya Nagar, and to board deluxe buses, pedestrians and commuters have to cross far outside the GH (General). But commuters and pedestrians cross the stretch though a gap between the median walls.

The traffic wing of the Commissionerate has installed a pedestrian signal post on GST Road near Durga Colony Road.

The post has to be facilitated between the median walls to help the pedestrians cross the road rather than making them put their lives at risk. An elevated pedestrian crossing has to be facilitated to prevent vehicular traffic.

S. Sulochana is a resident of Tambaram Sanatorium

Relay roads in New Perungalathur

S. ABOORVA

In March-April, the roads in Kamatchi Nagar Extension, New Perungalathur, were dug up to lay underground electricity cables. While the cable-laying work seems to be completed, the roads have not been relaid.

School buses cannot enter Muthuvelar Street, forcing parents to drop off and pick up their children at a location far from their homes.

As a mother of school-going children, I am expected to drop my children off at different locations around the same time,



which has become extremely difficult.

The narrow road also creates traffic bottlenecks, and it is worse during the rains.

Water accumulates on the dug-up areas, making it impos-



ble to locate them and increasing the risk of accidents.

The authorities in the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation

should take immediate action to relay the roads.

S. Aboorva is a resident of New Perungalathur

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeed-back@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

Escalator at Chromepet FOB is up and running



The new escalator at the Chromepet footbridge on GST Road.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

The defunct escalator at Chromepet footbridge, which was replaced with a new one, began operating from June 23, providing relief to commuters.

S. Pushpa, a pedestrian, says, “Earlier pedestrians struggled before reaching the walkway at the bridge as the staircases were steep.”

R. Manjula, a pedestrian, says, “There is a lot of space to facili-

tate a downward moving escalator, which should have been provided.”

Years ago, along the eastern lane of GST Road, there was an escalator connecting the walkway on the bridge. The facility was removed to construct a double-discharge platform at the station. The facilities (downward moving) are much needed now, as commuters and pedestrians use the staircases at the bridge, a portion of which has been constructed by the Southern Railway. There is

ample space along the staircases to provide the facilities.

Social activist V. Santhanam thanked the Divisional Engineer of the Highways Department (City Roads Division), Thirunavukarasu, and Assistant Engineer Senthilkumar.

He asked the Highways Department to provide flooring along the escalator facade and to fence off the area to prevent motorcyclists from parking. “Along the walkway at the bridge, a gate must be installed,” he said.

Mini dump on a vacant plot in Pammal

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

A section of residents at Nethaji Street in VOC Nagar, Pammal have been living in an insalubrious environment. A vacant plot on the stretch is used as a mini dump. The walkway and carriageway along the plot are not spared and are littered with silt and garbage.

One can see all kinds of trash, including construction debris and a sofa set dumped on the road. The garbage attracts cattle and dogs, creating fear among road users.

K. Chandrasekar, a resident, says, “Complaints to the former Pammal Municipality and the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation have not yielded any response.

The plot’s facade had walls and a gate in between, but due to

dumping of sand it broke. Garbage now spills into the stormwater drain network, running with sewage, and turning into a breeding ground for mosquitoes.

S. Sivakumar, another resident, says, “Residents and people from hotels arrive in vehicles to dump garbage in this plot. When conservancy staff are absent for days, illegal dumping increases.”

There is a pre-primary school located along the plot, raising concerns about the potential spread of infection among children due to garbage being dumped.

Recently, teachers were rebuked by members of the public for asking people to refrain from dumping garbage. The Corporation clears waste daily, but illegal dumping continues.



The plot attracts cattle and dogs. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Book Swap: stories on the move

The gathering coincided with the 21st OMR Book Swap, a reader-driven initiative that gives books a second life by encouraging participants to exchange completed titles for new ones. This edition saw nearly 150 books find new homes. The success of the swap was made possible by volunteers Anitha, Madhmitha, Sharmishtha, Gokulakannan, Poornima, Harishkumar, Darshika, the team Casa Grand Amethyst Arun, Raghavi, Naveen, Mounika, Ravi among others. We also thank Sriram, Sunitha and Ramasamy for contributing towards the boxes for safekeeping of the 1000 books between swaps.

Book Breakout: spotlight on Ram Naam Satya Hai

Ram Naam Satya Hai, the debut novel of OMR resident Renu Chhotaria, was launched during the meet. In conversation with FOMRRA volunteer Ranjit Narayanan, the author shared insights into her modern mythological interpretation of the Ramayana. The book revisits several contentious episodes from the epic through a contemporary storytelling lens, sparking lively discussions among members who offered diverse perspectives on the themes explored in the novel.

Shutterbugs join bookworms at OMR

HARSHA KODA

The Bookworms Club, the literary arm of FOMRRA, held its 8th meeting on June 14, 2026, at Casa Grand Amethyst, Sholinganallur, bringing together readers, nature enthusiasts, and residents for an engaging afternoon of books and discussion.

The major highlight of the latest meeting of The Booworms Club was the launch of a club that would help photographers, professional and amateur, on OMR to meet and share notes

Book Breakdowns: Where the Crawdads Sing

A lively discussion centred on Delia Owens’ bestselling novel *Where the Crawdads Sing*, selected for the meet by Sriram Janak, a nature and wildlife photographer from OMR. Set in the marshlands of North Carolina during the 1960s, the novel blends crime, survival and nature writing through the story of a young girl growing up in isolation. Members also compared the book with its successful film adaptation, concluding that the novel’s vivid depiction of marshland life and human resilience offered a richer experience than the movie’s stronger emphasis on the mystery plot.

In keeping with the book’s environmental themes, Bhuvana Raj, a lead member of FOMRRA’s Eco Watch initiative, shared insights on marshland ecosystems and the importance of protecting habitats such as the Pallikaranai Marsh. She highlighted the impact of rapid urbanisation and stressed the need for residents to safeguard these natural buffers against flooding and other ecological challenges.

Seeing the interest among the crowd for the visual beauty of the marsh FOMRRA also launched the ShutterBugs group to showcase and discuss photography among members. (<https://shutterbugs.fomrra.org>)

The meeting concluded with members selecting Jane Austen’s classic *Sense and Sensibility* as the book for the next gathering, continuing the club’s tradition of collectively choosing its next literary journey.

The legacy bearers

As India observes National Reading Month from June 19 to July 18, a peek into two popular used-books shops in Chennai that survive because the women running them want to preserve what has been bequeathed to them, despite daunting odds

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

R.K. Alwar did not want his books to be interred with his bones; and that was his final wish, not expressed on his deathbed but when he realised he was doddering towards it. Alwar's daughters Ammu and Julie have honoured that wish against daunting odds, ensuring the iconic Alwar Book Shop stays rooted to the spot where it has always stood at Luz Church Road in Mylapore. Alwar passed on in 2018 and since then his daughters have witnessed a parade of reasons to go back on their promise. If they had, nobody could have faulted them for it. The pandemic tested their resolve and the ongoing Metro Rail work has done the same thing. But these events had only ended up playing the devil's advocate, revealing to the world that this resolve comes with a cladding of steel.

Around Luz Corner and on this section of Luz Church Road, multiple retail businesses have trotted away in disappointment, but the duo has held on bound by that promise. Metro Rail construction has made Alwar Book Shop difficult to access, barricades and route diversions have discouraged many regulars from visiting it, and the once bustling pavement book shop is marked by a con-



(Above) Alwar's four daughters (from left) Eliza, Ammu, Julie and Lucy at Alwar Book Shop; and Alwar with his family.

spicuous lull. And changing reading habits induced by digital technology is queering the pitch further. But get this right, the daughters bear Alwar's legacy (which is their mother Ma-

ry's too; she also passed on in 2018) not as a burden, but as believers in it. There are believers from outside the family too. For them, Alwar's affable nature makes it compelling to believe

in his legacy and dream, which began in 1939. Ammu points out there are still a good number of customers best described as "loyal patrons"; they continue visiting the book shop because of their affection for Alwar.

The sisters take turns to look after the book shop both living just a stone's throw away from it for easy accessibility and for the unstated reason of refreshing memories. Family time has been around this shop. After marriage, Mary joined Alwar in managing the shop. Ammu recalls her maternal grandmother worked as a nanny at Good Shepherd Convent and, as a child her mother often accompanied her to the school, gradually acquiring English language with its myriad nuances. Though neither of their parents had extensive formal education, their love for literature was immense. "Our mother spoke English beautifully, and both our parents knew books and authors better than most people I have met," Ammu recalls in a tone betraying boundless admiration.

For their father, the bookstore was never merely a business; it provided him with meaning for existence; it was a dream he gave his youth away for. Ammu remembers how her father never spent a single night away from the shop and would brave torrential downpours to ensure not even a corner of a shop got drenched. She laughs while recalling, "He loved books so much that he would absent-mindedly call almost everything a book, even if it was a piece of cloth."

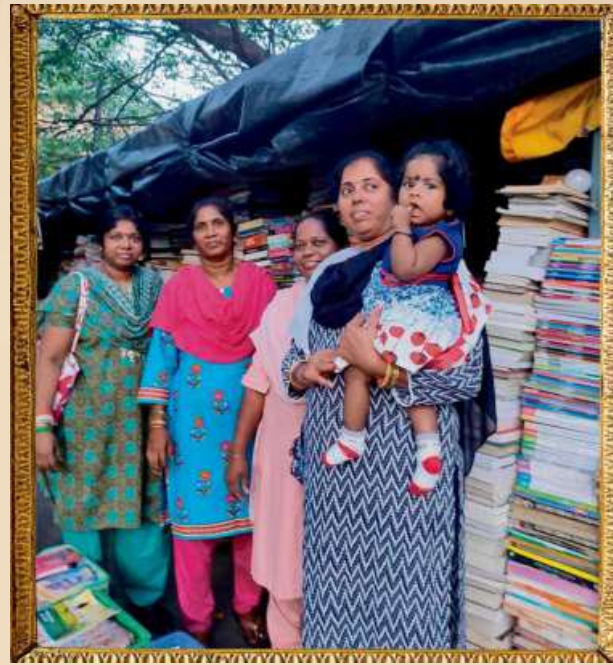
Perhaps the irony is the greatest story at the Alwar Book Shop is not inside any of those

thousands of books lining its shelves, and it is unwritten. This story is lived out every day by two daughters: returning to the same spot, made hallow by his father for those who worship learning and knowledge.

Ammu believes their father has never truly left the bookstore he established at this spot when he was around 16 years old.

Her voice choking and tears in her eyes, Ammu adds, "My dad is still here. We know he is. That is why we will never give up on this shop, even on our hardest days."

Alwar Book Shop, open from 10 a.m. to 7:30 p.m., offering fiction, non-fiction and academic books can be contacted at 9884773591



Scrap dealers probably do not warm up to old books with the same intensity as before; but surprises do crop up

The neighbourhood Kabadiwala as the bookseller

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Before the digital revolution, "waste paper mart" was a handy hanger for synecdoche the literary device. Old newspapers and books were always the unlikely bully in a scrap shop, elbowing even heavy metal scrap to the sidelines. In a bloodless synecdochic takeover, these fragile items proudly represented the whole of scrap materials. And the neighbourhood Kabadiwala invariably appended "waste paper mart" to their shop's name. Rajalakshmi Waste Paper Mart on East Coast Road (ECR) in Pallavakkam established 26 years ago mirrors this practice.

Its owner T. Ponraja is winding up operations at Pallavakkam, the shutters to be downed for the final time sometime next week, when he would be launching into his second innings at a new address in Injambakkam on ECR, carrying over lessons and scrap items, not all of them, certainly not the used books and stacks of old newspapers. He notes he is going to the next level, and reveals there is no room for old newspapers and books up there. "I will focus on wooden and metal scrap."

Even at Pallavakkam, the old newspapers and books were not raking in the shekels; a whole truckload of other scraps did that for Ponraja. But he would



T. Ponraja has lost faith in sale of old books as a revenue stream; and (below) Abdur Rasheed believes a demand for them continues to exist.



still display old books he received, on a metal rack right next to where he would be seated. He would not sell those books by a standard weight math, but by deliberate pricing of each individual book, turning over to see the price on the cover. He wanted book lovers to purchase from him. Over the years as smartphone models became thinner, the stacks of books coming in became correspondingly lighter. Good used

book titles were slow in making it to the shelf and slower still leaving it. He has spread out the last stack of books on the shelf. And these books might be waiting for readers that will probably never arrive. No problem with the quality of the collection; only that their time under the sun is up. "Even if I sell a book worth ₹499 for ₹100, there are no buyers," says Ponraja, believing the downward slide began during the pandemic, and is speeding as dependence on technology for information deepens by the minute. "There was a time when he would have a steady stream of customers looking for old books. Their enthusiasm motivated me to collect more books. Now, I have lost my motivation." This is a recurrent theme across neighbourhood scrap shops, many of them not drawn anymore to keeping old books for sale. And that contrasts sharply with how in the past neighbourhood Kabadiwa-

las headlined the chapter on old books in the circular economy. They would welcome old books jettisoned out of households. Sellers of old books would buy from them on the cheap, usually by weight; sometimes residents would be buyers, in which case, the price would be higher but still strikingly affordable. These books would find a cosy shelf in a new home and then again be offloaded onto a tricycle to be carted to a Kabadiwala shop.

While a majority of Kabadiwalas believe the death knell for the used books trade is progressively getting louder, do not be surprised to meet some who continue to believe in it. Abdur Rasheed runs a scrap shop at East Abhiramapuram First Street in Mylapore where a notable display is a wall-mounted metal shelf which is always populated by used books that are sold by weight, a fixed ₹80 per kg. Books might contribute to a negligible part of his income, but he still buys them as scrap, displays them prominently for sale. Explains Abdur: "There is still demand for books; there are still customers coming for books, because of which I go and fetch books. It is an amalgamation of fresh and old books, often both in good condition."

In this National Reading Month, such stories are a sliver of hope for lovers of printed books.

The bookmark shifted from a page of grief to one of growth

On Mount Road, Siva Book House tells a similar tale of loss, memory and resilience. Founded and nurtured by brothers Siva and Sundaramurthy in 1977, the bookstore located in a shopping complex on Blackers Road off Mount Road is now run by Sundaramurthy's wife, Malliga with the assistance of their son Maheshwaran. For nearly six years, the mother-son duo has kept the shelves occupied, refusing to let the bookstore become a forgotten chapter. A homemaker for most of her life, Malliga never once imagined she would one day run the very store she used to visit only to bring lunch for her husband, whom she fondly calls "my sir". It was Maheshwaran, their younger son who insisted the shop should not end with his father's passing and patiently taught her the

nuances of bookselling. She now travels across Chennai using various modes of public transport to collect books as per the trends; a routine once unknown to her now defines her life.

The store, open from 10:30 a.m. to 8:00 p.m., has a range that extends from magazines and fiction to non-fiction and academic books. Siva Book House was a prominent presence on the pavement on Mount Road just a dozen footsteps away from the Anna Salai Post Office. Overtaken by various changes that unfolded on that section, including the razing of a shopping complex, Siva Book House moved "indoors" into this shopping complex on Blackers Road. With reduced visibility, the bookstore thrives largely on the patronage of old customers.

"If someone urgently needs a book,

I will come as early as nine in the morning," Malliga smiles.

She fondly remembers how her husband handpicked every collection and occasionally took a young Maheshwaran along, unknowingly nurturing his love for books. Books entered Malliga's world through her husband's voice rather than the printed page. "My sir would narrate stories to me because I was not comfortable with reading any language," she recalls. "I may not have read them all, but I still remember every story he told." Though sales has declined with the rise of digital reading, Malliga believes technology can never replace the joy of walking into a bookstore, breathing in the scent of paper, and finding solace among the shelves. Their regular customers include teachers, government employees and media professionals.

Long after all the books on its shelves have been read, Siva Book House will have a story to be read, outside those book covers: the story of a

woman who stepped outside the confines of her home, picked up her husband's unfinished chapter and found the courage to keep writing it.

Siva Book House can be contacted at 9952934175.



Sundaramurthy and (left) Malliga.

Comfort wheels

R. RAGU

One can pass up an occasion for banqueting, but not an opportunity to be of help to someone facing bereavement or is up against a health crisis, their own or a family member's. In bereavement and health crisis that draw the attention of the wider world because of the personalities involved, P.R.M.M. Shanthakumar has made his presence felt from time to time. His company, Flying Squad Ambulance Service, which offers emergency medical, mortuary and funeral services through its fleet of vehicles, some of them massively high-end, has been called on for assistance during loss and suffering involving big names.

Shanthakumar points out that director the body of K. Bhagyaraj was transported in his company's vehicle from the Apollo Hospital to the deceased director's home in Nungambakkam.

Shanthakumar underlines that his hearse vehicles had been pressed into service for three chief ministers of Tamil Nadu, carrying their mortal bodies; they are V. R. Nedunchezhiyan (who was briefly acting CM in 1969 and again in 1987), J. Jayalithaa and 'Kalaighar' M. Karunanidhi.

Shanthakumar explains that in recent times he is also focussed on providing a plush space for people to carry out rituals for their dear deceased. Based on a public-private partnership (PPP), in which he has tied up with Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC), he is offering a cosy air-conditioned space for the performance of rituals and funeral service at the Jones Road burial ground in Saidapet.

A GCC official familiar with the development says a 1,200 sq.ft space was extended to him for the purpose. Shanthakumar notes the built-up area of the facility measures 2,400 sq.ft. The facility is not far from completion, and its inauguration would be announced in the near future, according to the source.

Shanthakumar has already

Kilpauk resident P.R.M.M. Shanthakumar and his team are called on for assistance during bereavement and health crisis involving celebrities. His vehicle transported director K. Bhagyaraj's body from hospital to home. In collaboration with GCC, he will be starting a funeral services facility at the Jones Road burial ground in Saidapet soon



A 5G ambulance; a funeral services facility at New Avadi Road and an upcoming one at Jones Road. PHOTOS: RAGU R. & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT.



established a similar funeral services facility at the burial ground on New Avadi Road. These facilities being established in collaboration with Greater Chennai Corporation are headlined "Dignified Farewell".

Sixty-five-year-old Shanthakumar, a resident of Kilpauk Garden Colony in Kilpauk, reveals that became aware of the lack of ambulances and hearses when he had a ringside view of how a day goes at an auto stand outside Kilpauk medical college hospital. His father was an auto driver attached to the stand, and a young Shanthakumar, in his teens then, noticed how bodies were being transported in autos for want of hearse services.

Shanthakumar lists among his company's achievements the introduction of a women-led ambulance service, private mortuary, funeral services and pet funeral services. He draws attention to "two state-of-the-art '5G Super Smart Ambulances', equipped with the latest life-saving technologies; each machine fitted with air suspension systems, ensuring maximum comfort and stability for critically ill patients during transport." The services are offered across India, he notes. Other highlights of the services include eight paramedical Professionals, three on-call doctors to accompany patients during critical intercity and interstate transfers; and 120 staff members tasked with patient care, mortuary management and funeral support services.





Building dreams

GRT Jewellers' scholarship programme to support 1,000 students this academic year

When Darshini first came across information about GRT Jewellers' scholarship programme on WhatsApp, she almost dismissed it as spam.

Recently, the B.Com student stood among hundreds of recipients at GRT Mahalakshmi Vidyalaya in Tiruttani, receiving support she believes will bring her a step closer to her academic goals. For students gathered on the sprawling campus, the Endowment Scholarship ceremony was about more than financial assistance. For many, it was a reminder that educational aspirations need not be limited by financial circumstances.

As part of its Corporate Social Responsibility, GRT Jewellers distributed scholarships to students in the first phase of its 2026-27 scholarship programme. Nearly 1,000 students, including both existing and new benef-



Radhakrishnan, MD, addressing the students; and (above) from the event.

iciaries, are expected to receive support this year.

G.R. Radhakrishnan, managing director of GRT Jewellers, said the initiative reflects the company's long-

standing commitment to educational empowerment. He noted that the programme aims to recognise academic excellence while encouraging students to dream bigger and achieve greater heights despite financial challenges.

The initiative was launched in 2021 and has steadily expanded in scale and reach. While scholarships remain at its core, the programme increasingly focuses on students from government schools, those from economically disadvantaged families, and other underserved communities.

The initiative now includes mentorship and academic guidance to help students navigate educational and career decisions.

GRT is considering constructing a women's hostel to provide safe, affordable accommodation for women pursuing higher education away from home, the release added.

A tribute to three timeless legends of Tamil music

Anand Apartments in Thiruvannamiyur, in association with Besant Nagar-based Kadarkarai Kaalai Raagam (KKR365), will be presenting a musical tribute to three icons of Tamil cinema – Kaviyarasar Kannadasan, Mellisai Mannar M.S. Viswanathan, and Paadum Nila S.P. Balasubrahmanyam—on June 28, 2026 at 5.30 p.m at Hotel Matsya, Gandhi Nagar, Adyar.

The event commemorates the birth centenary year of Kaviyarasar Kannadasan and the birth month celebrations of M.S. Viswanathan and S.P. Balasubrahmanyam, honouring their enduring contribution to Tamil music and culture.

Anand Apartments, a vibrant residential community of over 150 families on L.B. Road, has celebrated arts, culture and community through its annual festivities for over four decades. KKR365 is a unique community of nearly 100 music lovers from diverse backgrounds who gather every morning at Besant Nagar Beach to keep the golden era of Tamil film music alive through singing songs.

For details call Chandrasekaran at +919444627370

Applications invited for best Tamil book award

Tamil Development Department of Government of Tamil Nadu has invited nominations for its annual award for best Tamil books. According to a press release, books published between January 1, 2025 and December 31, 2025 are applicable.

Works of poetry, novel, short story, drama, history, linguistics, grammar, fine arts (music, painting, dance, and sculpture), biography, autobiography, history, epigraphy, archaeology, religion, spirituality and psychology apply.

Books translated into Tamil from other languages also apply.

Applications can be downloaded free of cost from the

website of the department's website tamilvalarchithurai@tn.gov.in and submitted. The last date for receipt of completed applications is August 31. For details, call 044-28190412 / 28190413.

ZIMSON celebrates Father's Day with collectors



Zimson, a leading multi-brand watch retailer, recently hosted 'Legacy of Time - A Father's Day Watch Collectors Meet' at V R Mall.

The event was jointly conducted by Zimson, VR Mall, Chennai, and Chronoholic India, an independent watch-collectors' community, bringing together enthusiasts, collectors, and luxury lifestyle patrons for an evening dedicated to horology.

Participants explored timepieces from Rado, Longines, Tissot, and Zimson, while exchanging stories, discussing collecting journeys, and discovering the craftsmanship behind renowned Swiss watch brands.

One of the highlights of the evening was an interactive

watch quiz hosted by Karan Madan, founder of Chronoholic India, where participants were tested on their knowledge of watchmaking history, iconic timepieces, and horological innovations.

Karan Madan said, "Watch collecting is about preserving stories, heritage, and craftsmanship. Events like these provide enthusiasts with an opportunity to learn from one another, discover exceptional timepieces, and inspire the next generation of collectors."

An interactive and insightful session with the audience featured engaging conversations about watch-buying journeys, ownership experiences, antique mechanical clocks, and pocket watch collections, said the press release.

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LIFFY THOMAS

Two established colleges in Chennai are gearing up to welcome girls into their classrooms from this academic year, shedding the “male tag” attached to them over the decades.

Both the 184-year-old Pachaiyappa's College in Poonamalee High Road and 60-year-old C. Kandaswami Naidu College for Men in Anna Nagar (both run by the Pachaiyappas Trust Board) started taking baby steps towards transition into a co-educational system at the post-graduate level and for evening college respectively. This will be the first academic year when undergraduate courses would see a mixed classroom.

“We hope to fill at least 30 percent of undergraduate courses enrolling women this academic year. This percentage will be increased to 50 percent in the coming years,” says V. M. Muthuramalinga Andavar, principal of C. Kandaswami Naidu College.

Switching to a co-educational system is not a new trend, both at the school and college level, if one were to see how iconic institutions across cities have been taking this route.

In 2024, Government Arts College in Nandanam, one of the oldest men's college in the city, opened its gates for girls. Likewise, some years ago, MCC Higher Secondary School in Chetpet



A healthy shift

An increasing number of institutions in Chennai are opting for a mixed gender educational system

switched from a boys-only school to enrolling girls as well.

Annai Veilankanni's College of Arts and Science in Saidapet has also opened its doors for both boys and girls from this academic year, both at under graduation and post graduation.

In fact the college has transitioned from a women's only college to a co-educational institute to

again switch to only accepting women and now it is a mixed gender institute.

“In 2000, the college started as women's institute and after two years switched to co-education continued with the system for five years. Today, many parents and students are increasingly preferring a co-ed institute and one with a Deemed University status,” says

V. Radhika, principal, Annai Veilankanni's College, adding that the management offers free education to deserving students.

Certain legacy institutions that are expanding their scope of education are also going the mixed way.

For example, Good Shepherd flagged off its centenary year celebrations a couple of years ago by

announcing launch of Good Shepherd Centenary School, a co-educational institution attached to the ICSE Board located on the same campus in College Road.

Why are some institutions moving towards co-education? Declining enrolment in single-gender institutions and growing parental preference for inclusive learning environments are key factors driving the shift.

Former headmaster and correspondent of MCC Higher Secondary School, G. J. Manohar, during whose time the co-educational stream was introduced, says the mixed classroom has certainly seen many positive outcomes, but there are challenges as well and it depends on how institutions handle gender equations.

“Today's workplace is all inclusive and to prepare them to face a heterogeneous group, it is better we bring them up in such an environment early on. I have noticed that children studying in a mixed group are better at appreciating gender values, and mutual respect is developed,” says Manohar, secretary, MCC Association.

Nirmala Krishnan, an educational consultant who has helped start many institutions, says research points out that those growing and learning in an inclusive environment are emotionally stronger and more confident of facing the world. She says gender sensitisation is best learnt and experienced in a mixed environment.

MOP, DG Vaishnav send most sportspersons for tournaments

The institutions recently won the Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

MOP Vaishnav College is regarded as one of the city's leading institutions when it comes to supporting sports and nurturing athletes. The college offers free education to sportspersons. It has also established a strong record in inter-collegiate and inter-zonal competitions, where it consistently figures among the top performers.

The college recently received the Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy in the women's section for having sent the highest number of sportspersons to represent the University of Madras in tournaments across India. Remarkably, it was the 23rd consecutive year that the college had won the prestigious



award.

MOP Vaishnav College won the Sivanthi Adityan Rolling Trophy in the women's section while DG Vaishnav won it in the men's section.

While MOP Vaishnav continued its stranglehold on the trophy, the rise of DG Vaishnav College has been the talk of the town. The Arumbakkam-based institution has now won the corresponding award in the men's



section for the third successive year ((2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26), surpassing established colleges such as Loyola College and Madras Christian College.

“It was possible only because of the unstinted support from our college management and our principal, Archana Prasad,” said Amudha Sumankumar, Director of Physical Education at MOP Vaishnav.

Similarly, M. Karthikeyan, Director of Physical Education at DG Vaishnav, credited the college management and principal Santhosh Babu for the hat-trick of triumphs.

“We too offer free education to our sportspersons. Without the Management's support, we would not have been able to achieve what we have over the last three years,” he said.

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